

**SHILPA PANDYA****ROLE:**

Deputy Director, Safety and Systems Reliability, Space Applications Centre (SAC), Ahmedabad

**CONTRIBUTION:**

Ensures safety and reliability of all spacecraft payload systems designed, preventing failures

**UMA DEVI G.****ROLE:**

Deputy Director, Satellite Data Reception and In-Situ Applications, National Remote Sensing Centre, Hyderabad

**CONTRIBUTION:**

Manages satellite data reception and processing for disaster management, etc.

**JOLLY DHAR****ROLE:**

Engineer in Electrical Systems Service, SAC, Ahmedabad

**CONTRIBUTION:**

She is responsible for the fabrication of electrical systems of payloads, ensuring their proper functioning during missions

**T. LATHA****ROLE:**

Deputy Director, Electronics Systems and Actuators, Vikram Sarabhai Space Centre, Thiruvananthapuram

**CONTRIBUTION:**

Oversees electronic systems, components, and control elements of spacecraft

**SOURCE** ISRO, DEPARTMENT OF SCIENCE & TECHNOLOGY, GOVERNMENT OF INDIA AND BT RESEARCH

technology. Scientists such as Neelavathy regularly visit remote areas to host events during National Science Day and World Space Week and ignite curiosity in science among students.

The government has several programmes, such as Women in Science and Engineering-KIRAN and Gender Advancement for Transforming Institutions, to attract more women into space sciences. The National Policy for Space Activities incorporates gender perspectives, while workshops and space camps inspire girls to pursue careers in space.

**SKY IS THE LIMIT**

According to Invest India, the Indian space sector is known for developing cost-effective satellites, successfully launching Mars probes on its first attempt, and launching hundreds of foreign satellites into space. India accounts for 2-3% of the global space economy, which could cross 10% by 2030. Women from the private sector, with increasing interest in the field, are expected to play a significant role here. For instance, Saraniya Periaswamy and Umamaheswari K. played key roles in launching the

first rocket with a 3D-printed engine developed by a start-up, Agnikul Cosmos, in Sriharikota. They managed the project from inception to launch.

Saraniya, 31, Executive Vice President at Agnikul, represents the new generation of women in India's private space industry. Her journey into space technology was unexpected. Growing up in the Andaman and Nicobar Islands, she wasn't sure of her career path but was drawn to Isro's work. "I didn't think I'd make it through the interviews, but after four rounds, I became the fourth employee at Agnikul," she explains.

Women-led start-ups offer innovative solutions and new perspectives. "While female-led start-ups face challenges in securing funding, the successes we see today are changing perceptions," she says.

**THE RISING STARS**

While Indian women in space are gaining visibility, there is still room for further recognition and opportunity. Saraniya emphasises the need for supportive policies that address gender imbalances in the sector. "Encouraging women beyond entry-

level positions through mentorship and leadership training is crucial," she notes. Her experience at Agnikul has been positive, characterised by an environment encouraging diversity without noticeable gender barriers. Saraniya says early exposure to STEM education is essential. "Promoting scholarships and organising events to empower girls and raise awareness about STEM opportunities is important," she says.

As India's space ambitions continue to evolve, women's contributions will play a significant role in shaping the future of space exploration. Whether it's through technical roles, policy frameworks, or entrepreneurship, their influence is set to grow. "This is just the beginning. We are writing history," Neelavathy asserts, echoing the sentiments of her colleagues and mentors.

The path may be challenging, but the shared vision of scientists, engineers, and entrepreneurs continues to inspire the next generation. As Neelavathy says, "The sky is not the limit; it's just the beginning." **BT**

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